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DURATION
11 Nights · 12 Days

ROUTE
Kochi return

PACE
Relaxed

BEST SEASON
October to March

IDEAL FOR
Couples, Families, Seniors

Some places you visit. Kerala, you sink into. This twelve-day journey moves at the pace of the land itself, from the spice-scented lanes of old Kochi, up through mist-wrapped tea gardens perched a mile above sea level, into forests where wild elephants still outnumber roads, and finally down onto water, where the last days unfold aboard a gently drifting houseboat and along a beach once ranked among the world's finest.

Every layer of Kerala's long, layered history is here for the finding: Portuguese churches and a centuries-old Jewish synagogue in Fort Kochi, Chinese fishing nets swinging against the sunset, hand-plucked tea rolling over the Kannan Devan Hills, tigers and elephants moving through Periyar's reserve, and a maze of backwater canals that has earned the region its nickname, the Venice of the East. This is Kerala at a traveller's pace: never rushed, always arriving somewhere worth the drive.

Journey Highlights

- **Wander** Fort Kochi's Portuguese churches, ancient mosques and 16th-century Jewish synagogue, and watch the iconic Chinese fishing nets at work.
- **Drive** into Munnar's Kannan Devan Hills, home to South India's highest peak and tea gardens that roll on for miles.
- **Visit** the Tata Tea Museum and Atukkad Waterfalls, and take in Western Ghats views from Top Station.
- **Cruise** Periyar Lake by boat in search of wild elephants, tigers and langurs inside a protected tiger reserve.
- **Spend** a night aboard a traditional kettuvallam houseboat, drifting through Alappuzha's backwater canals.
- **Unwind** at Mararikulam Beach, ranked by National Geographic among the world's top five hammock beaches.
- **Discover** centuries-old temples and churches around Cherthala and Arthunkal, including one of the largest shrines in the world.

Itinerary at a Glance

DAY	DESTINATION	SIGNATURE EXPERIENCE
Day 01	Kochi	Arrival; settle into the Queen of the Arabian Sea
Day 02	Kochi	Fort Kochi churches, synagogue and Chinese fishing nets
Day 03	Munnar	Drive into misty tea country on the Kannan Devan Hills
Day 04	Munnar & Kodaikanal	Waterfalls, tea museum and Top Station views

DAY	DESTINATION	SIGNATURE EXPERIENCE
Day 05	**Thekkady (Periyar)**	Drive to the Periyar Tiger & Elephant Reserve
Day 06	**Thekkady (Periyar)**	Boat safari on Periyar Lake and spice-hill treks
Day 07	**Alappuzha**	Into the backwaters, the Venice of the East
Day 08	**Alappuzha**	Overnight aboard a traditional kettuvallam houseboat
Day 09	**Mararikulam**	Coastal drive to one of the world's top hammock beaches
Day 10	**Mararikulam**	Beach day, with optional temple visits at Cherthala
Day 11	**Mararikulam**	Leisure day; historic churches and temples nearby
Day 12	**Departure**	Transfer to Kochi airport for onward travel

Day by Day

Expand all

Day 01 Kochi: Queen of the Arabian Sea

Arrive in Kochi and transfer to your hotel. This port city blends the architectural fingerprints of medieval Holland, Portugal and England with centuries of Arab trading history. Its name comes from the Malayalam Kochazhi, meaning small lagoon, and it was Vasco da Gama who first put the city on the world map. Famed for its spice trade and its Kathakali dance tradition, Kochi is a gentle introduction to Kerala.

Explore Kochi →

Overnight in Kochi

Day 02 Fort Kochi: Churches, Synagogue and Fishing Nets

Spend the morning among Kochi's most storied corners: Portuguese churches, ancient mosques and temples, and the historic Jewish synagogue. Don't miss the Chinese fishing nets: ten-metre cantilevered structures worked by a team of fishermen using a stone counterweight system unchanged for generations. In the afternoon, stroll through Hill Palace, Kochi Fort, Marine Drive and Cherai Beach at your own pace.

Explore Kochi →

Overnight in Kochi

Day 03 Into the Hills: Kochi to Munnar

Drive · Drive 172 km

Climb from Kochi into Munnar, Kerala's largest tea-growing region, set across the Kannan Devan Hills. Mist clings to the peaks as the road rises toward Anamudi, South India's highest summit, through sanctuaries home to the grizzled giant squirrel, gaur, elephant, sambar and Nilgiri langur. If timing is on your side you might glimpse the rare Neelakurinji flower, which blooms only once every twelve years.

Explore Kochi →

Overnight in Munnar

Day 04 Munnar: Waterfalls, Tea and Top Station

Explore the wider Munnar region. Visit the Atukkad Waterfalls, tucked between hills and jungle, then continue to Chithirapuram's tea estates and the Floriculture Centre. Take in sweeping Western Ghats views from Top Station, and learn how the leaves in your cup are grown and processed at the Tata Tea Museum. The day reaches toward Kodaikanal, the Princess of Hill Stations, before returning to Munnar for the night.

Overnight in Munnar

Day 05 Munnar to Thekkady: Into Tiger Country

Drive · Drive 159 km

Continue by road to Thekkady, home of the Periyar Tiger and Elephant Reserve. Watch for Indian elephants, Bengal tigers, wild boar, sambar, leopard and langur across the reserve's forests, and bring a camera for its rich birdlife. Surrounding coffee and tea plantations make a scenic backdrop, and for the more adventurous a short trek into the hills is well worth the time.

Overnight in Thekkady

Day 06 Periyar: A Day on the Water

Boat · Lake boat safari

Spend the day in and around Periyar National Park, some 700 square kilometres of dense forest and savanna grassland. Take a boat ride to watch herds of elephants and other wildlife along the water's edge, browse the local bazaars, or set off on a soft trek into the surrounding hills. Nearby Murikkady and Chellar Kovil reward anyone wanting to explore further afield.

Overnight in Thekkady

Day 07 Alappuzha: Venice of the East

Drive · Drive 109 km

Drive to Alappuzha, once known as Alleppey and fondly nicknamed the Venice of the East for its maze of canals, backwaters, lagoons and beaches. A cruise through the backwaters here is one of Kerala's essential experiences. Nearby Kuttanad, Kerala's rice bowl, is one of the few places on earth where rice is cultivated below sea level, its paddies framed by coconut palms.

Overnight in Alappuzha

Day 08 Aboard a Kettuvallam: A Night on the Backwaters

Boat · Overnight houseboat

Today is dedicated to Alappuzha's true calling card. Board a traditional kettuvallam (once used to ferry grain, now converted into a floating cottage with sleeping quarters, a dining area and a deck to relax on) and drift through a network of lakes and canals shaped by rivers, waves and shifting shore currents. Meals are prepared fresh on board by your crew as the backwaters slip quietly by.

Overnight aboard the houseboat

Day 09 Mararikulam: To the Coast

Drive · Drive 11 km

Drive to Mararikulam, a quiet beach village a short distance from Alappuzha. Mararikulam Beach was rated by National Geographic among the world's top five hammock beaches, reason enough to slow down entirely. Spend the evening unwinding by the shore and easing into the pace of coastal Kerala life.

Overnight in Mararikulam

Day 10 Cherthala: Beach Days and Nearby Temples

A full day at leisure on Mararikulam Beach, with the option to explore nearby Cherthala and several of its important temples. The Karthyayani Devi Temple draws devotees year-round and shares its complex with shrines to Vishnu, Shiva, Ayyappa and Kshethrapalakan. The Muttathu Thirumala Devaswam Temple is known for its deities Saligrama and Sree Venkatachalapathy Moorthy.

Overnight in Mararikulam

Day 11 Arthunkal: Leisure and Heritage

A second day to enjoy the beach or explore further afield. Visit Saint Augustine Church near Aroor, one of the oldest Latin Catholic churches in the region, along with the Karthyayani and Vattakkeril temples. In Arthunkal, St. Andrew's Basilica stands as one of the largest shrines in the world. Round out the day at Thycattusserry's Devi temple and Christian church.

Overnight in Mararikulam

Day 12 Kochi: Departure

Transfer to Kochi airport for your onward flight, bringing to a close a journey through Kerala's hills, wildlife reserves, backwaters and shores.

Explore Kochi →

Departure day

Practical notes

Best time to visit

October to March brings dry, comfortable days across the hills, reserve and backwaters.

Getting there

Cochin International Airport (COK) is the arrival and departure point for this route.

Ideal duration

Twelve days lets the hills, the reserve and the backwaters each get their due without rushing.

Pace

Relaxed. Longer drives sit on transfer days, with full leisure days on the coast.